

World in Brief: A South Korean giant eyes an American IPO; Trump's battle over election rules



Photograph: Reuters

SK Hynix, the world's second-largest chipmaker, said it was looking to raise up to \$29.4bn on America's Nasdaq exchange. The South Korean tech giant recently overtook [Samsung](#) as the country's most valuable company. Its landmark listing could exceed the \$25.6bn sum raised by Saudi Aramco's initial public offering in 2019, a global record until [SpaceX's \\$75bn IPO](#) this month.

A federal judge barred **Donald Trump** from requiring proof of citizenship to register to vote, after several states sued him over an executive order seeking to change **election rules**. The president is separately pressuring the Senate to pass a bill containing that requirement, and another to bring [photo identification](#) to cast a ballot. On Wednesday he cancelled plans to sign a housing package until lawmakers agreed.

Israel said it would maintain its military presence in **southern Lebanon**. [The two countries](#) are negotiating an American-backed plan under which Israeli forces would cede parts of the territory they control to Lebanon's army. Separately, Iran has demanded that

Israel end its campaign against Hizbullah, a militia backed by the Islamic regime, as part of its tentative peace deal with America.

The **International Atomic Energy Agency**, a nuclear watchdog, said inspections of Iran's uranium enrichment sites would go ahead soon, but "dates, procedures, places" were yet to be agreed.

America and Iran disagree on the details of [the arrangement](#): Mr Trump has said that Iran has agreed to nuclear-weapons inspections, but Iran denies this.

Finland's unemployment rate reached 12.7% in May—its highest since 2000—up from 10.5% a year earlier. The Nordic country now has the highest joblessness rate in the European Union, surpassing Spain. Its economy relies heavily on exports, particularly of metals and petrochemicals, and has suffered from weak demand and disruptions relating to wars in Ukraine and Iran.

Keiko Fujimori appears set to win Peru's presidential run-off after the right-wing politician secured a lead over Roberto Sánchez, her left-wing rival. Mr Sánchez alleged—without evidence—that the election is fraudulent. Ms Fujimori's victory would bring Peru into sync with a broader [rightward shift across Latin America](#); voters concerned about crime and economic stagnation are increasingly backing conservative candidates.

Britain and Italy both issued their highest **heat warnings**, as **Europe** swelters under [record-breaking temperatures](#). The mercury has hit the low-40s in some parts of France and Spain, closing schools and disrupting travel. In France at least 48 people have drowned over the past week while escaping the heat in rivers and canals. Temperatures have also wiped out hundreds of thousands of chickens.

Figure of the day: \$5.30 a pound, the price pistachios fetched in America in May, the highest figure in a decade. Read about the Iran war's impact on [nuts in California](#).

The politics of jubilation



Photograph: Getty Images

America's 250th birthday is approaching and Donald Trump is ready to party. The president is selling "Trump 250" branded blankets (\$200), jigsaws (\$50) and golf balls (\$18). Coins minted with Mr Trump's face are on the way. For a limited time his portrait will be printed into new American passports issued out of Washington (priceless). On Wednesday Mr Trump hosts an opening ceremony for the Great American State Fair, a patriotic jamboree running in the capital until July 10th.

The event is organised by Freedom 250, a group created by the Trump administration that is separate from America250, Congress's commission for nationwide celebrations created in 2016. States are also holding their own festivities. That has led to confusion and fights over funding. Several musicians have dropped out of Mr Trump's fair citing concerns about politicisation; the president called their acts "overpriced" and declared himself the headliner. Planning a party is no piece of cake.

Pedro Sánchez plays the victim



Photograph: Alamy

When Pedro Sánchez, Spain's prime minister, addressed parliament on Wednesday about the scandals enveloping his Socialist Workers' Party he presented himself as a victim. A maverick judge has sent his wife to trial on charges that she used her influence to get, and profit from, a university job for which she was unqualified. He ordered her to surrender her passport, saying (improbably) that her police escort might help her flee. She denies wrongdoing. Ministers complain that the judge has a political agenda.

That has distracted attention from more serious cases against Socialist officials. On Monday José Luis Ábalos, Mr Sánchez's former right-hand man, was sentenced to 24 years for taking bribes on contracts for face masks during the pandemic. Others are also being investigated for corruption. Erstwhile allies of the prime minister as well as the conservative opposition are demanding that he [call an election](#). But he insists he will stay until one is due next year.

Can memory-chip makers keep growing?



Photograph: Getty Images

Few parts of the technology industry have benefited more from the [artificial-intelligence boom](#) than memory-chip makers, whose shares have soared over the past year. On Wednesday investors will scrutinise quarterly financial results published by Micron Technology, an American producer, for signs of whether the rally can continue.

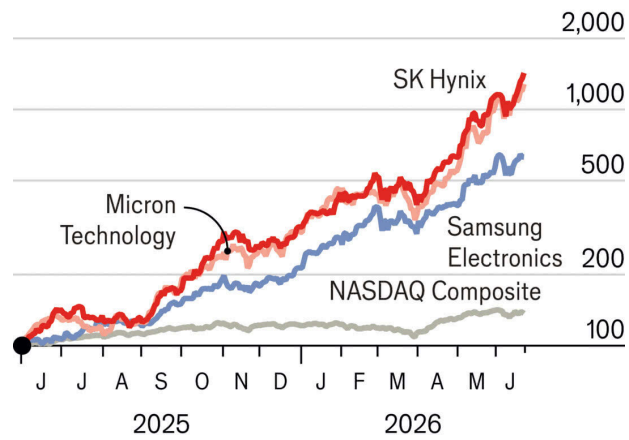
In recent days it has faltered. The shares of sk Hynix, a South Korean manufacturer, dropped by more than 10% on Tuesday and Micron's are down by 7%. One worry is that higher memory costs could [depress demand for devices](#) that use them. Gartner, a consultancy, expects a drop in sales of consumer electronics this year, with PC shipments down by 10% and smartphone deliveries by 8%.

The memory-chip industry is prone to swing between shortage and glut. Right now, manufacturers are racing to expand production, but factories take years to build. Some investors fear that by the time they're ready, customers will not be as keen to buy the chips they'll make.

Value storage

Share prices, June 1st 2025=100

Log scale



Source: LSEG Workspace

An UNattractive job, but someone has to do it



Photograph: Alamy

Who would want to be secretary-general of the United Nations? Strongmen are undoing global order; the body is skint and often paralysed; and it is failing in its mission to “save succeeding generations from the scourge of war”. Yet at least six candidates want the thankless job, and are expected to appear at a think-tank forum in the South Korean town of Jeju on Thursday.

Buggins’ turn says a candidate from Latin America or the Caribbean should succeed António Guterres, a European. No woman has held the job. Cue five hopefuls from the region (a mix of ex-presidents, ministers and UN officials) of which four are women: Michelle Bachelet of Chile; Carolyn Rodrigues-Birkett of Guyana; María Fernanda Espinosa Garcés of Ecuador; Rafael Mariano Grossi of Argentina; and Rebeca Grynspan of Costa Rica. Macky Sall of Senegal makes six.

The big powers will decide, so watch Mr Grossi, head of the International Atomic Energy Agency—especially if he can help facilitate a nuclear deal between America and Iran.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Which actor rose to fame playing a modern version of Sherlock Holmes before playing Dr Strange in various Marvel movies?

Tuesday: The singer Concetta Rosa Maria Franconero went under which stage name?

*A man must be strong enough to
mold the peculiarity of his
imperfections into the perfection
of his peculiarities.*

Walther Rathenau